

China



The world's most populous country, and for centuries the world's most advanced civilization.

6th–5th century BCE Confucius (c.551–c.479 BCE) passes his teachings down to his disciples to be recorded in the *Analects*. Confucian thought is supplemented by the teachings of Mencius in the 4th century BCE. Lao Zu (possibly mythical) creates the philosophy later set down in the *Dao De Jing* as Taoist thought. Han Fei Zi establishes the legalist school.

221 BCE China is unified for the first time under an imperial dynasty, the Qin, with its capital in Chang'an (present day Xi'an). The first emperor, Shi Huangdi, infamous for his hardline suppression of subversion and mass execution of intellectuals, is also credited with the instigation of the Great Wall. Script and weights and measures are standardized.

206 BCE Liu Bang leads a peasant uprising to overthrow the Qin dynasty and establish the Han, under which China remains unified almost continually for more than four centuries. Stability allows major advances to be made in political thought, economics, invention, and administration, and Chinese territory is enlarged through several successful military campaigns.

6 CE The declining Han dynasty is usurped by Wang Mang who establishes the short-lived Xin dynasty.

25 CE The Han dynasty is restored with its capital farther east in Luoyang, for which reason the second Han period is known as the Eastern Han.

220 CE The Eastern Han fails to produce the stability and achievements of the earlier Western Han due to a succession of young and weak emperors, and the country splits into three warring kingdoms: Shu, Wei, and Wu.

265 CE The Northern and Southern dynasties period begins. During this period northern China is ruled by six different dynasties and the south by three.

589 Yang Jian, regent of the Northern Zhou dynasty conquers the Southern Chen dynasty and establishes the Sui, building a new capital in Luoyang. The Sui dynasty instigates many of the institutions developed to great success in the Tang: the administration, tax, forced labor, penal, and examination systems. The Grand Canal is constructed. Excessive demands on the peasants for forced labor under the second emperor of the Sui bring about a peasant revolt in 611 CE that heralds the end of the dynasty.

618 Li Yuan leads an army revolt and captures Chang'an, hereafter capital of the Tang, but in 626 CE passes the throne to his second son, Li Shimin, who becomes the famous Emperor Tai Zong of the Tang.

The political institutions of the Sui are reformed along less repressive lines and the empire consolidated. "Land equalization" is carried out. The Tang is referred to in Chinese history as a golden age, mostly for its arts (especially poetry and painting), which flourish under imperial patronage, and for unprecedented territorial expansion, but also for its political and religious tolerance.

755 Poor government leads to social disorder and An Lushan leads a rebellion, which takes eight years to quell. The Tang recovers sufficiently for almost another century of stability (mid-Tang), but social order declines due to power struggles within the court throughout the late Tang period (820–907 CE).

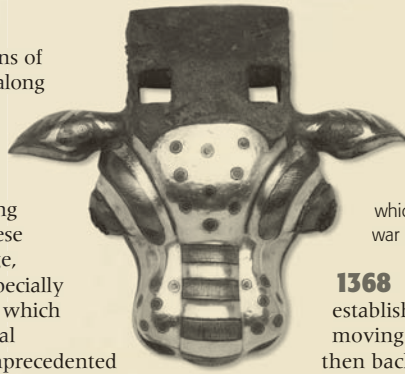
906 The collapse of the Tang produces 54 years of disunity when rule passes between five separate dynasties (Later Liang, Later Tang, Later Jin, Later Han, and Later Zhou). Parts of North China come under the rule of 10 non-Chinese kingdoms.

960 Zhou Kuangyin, commander of the Later Zhou's imperial army, leads a revolt to seize power, founds the Song dynasty, creating the capital in Kaifeng, and conquers the other Chinese states over a period of 15 years. In spite of rigorous attempts at centralizing control and defending itself against external attack, the Song never achieves the unity of the Tang. Political and military instability breeds philosophical and religious ferment, including the development of neo-Confucian thought, which draws from ideas in both Confucian traditions and Buddhism.

1127 The Jurchen conquest of northern China combines with factional struggles and peasant rebellions to effect the collapse of the Northern Song dynasty, which reestablishes itself in Hangzhou as the Southern Song. Northern China falls under the control of the Jurchen Jin dynasty. Military conflict continues between the two regimes. The writing of Ci poetry reaches its peak in the south. Mongol armies under Ghengis Khan begin their gradual conquest of China.

1275 Venetian explorer Marco Polo arrives in China. He will spend 17 years there in the service of Kublai Khan.

1279 The Mongol conquest of China is completed under Kublai Khan, and the Yuan dynasty established, bringing the capital to the site of present-day Beijing for the first time. Under the Mongols, agriculture, communications, and local administration are strengthened, drama flourishes, and advances are made in science and technology. A policy of tolerance is adopted toward religion. Like many dynasties before it, the Mongol dynasty deteriorates through corruption and is overthrown by peasant rebellions.



Chariot ornament

In the 4th century BCE, about the time this ornament adorned a Chinese war chariot, Sun Tzu wrote his treatise *The Art of War*, which included the maxim "all war is based on deception."

1368 Zhu Yuanzhang establishes the Ming dynasty, moving the capital to Nanjing, then back to Beijing in 1421.

1421 Policies are adopted to restore order in the countryside: land is allocated to refugees and taxation eased. The bureaucracy is reorganized. Indiscriminate executions and the establishment of a secret service ensure the unopposed rule of the emperor, and heavy censorship and editing of texts is instigated. The novel is introduced as a new form of literature and *The Water Margin* and *Journey to the West* ("Monkey") achieve particular acclaim. The dynasty is consistently shaken by peasant uprisings, and weakened by the excessive power of the eunuchs in the court. It is, however, Manchu invaders who bring about the fall of the Ming Dynasty.

1582 Portuguese traders arrive at Guangzhou.

1644 The Manchus conquer China, expand the region to an unprecedented extent, and modify the Qing institutions. They allow the Han to participate in government, while holding on to power. Wearing of the hair in a queue is made compulsory as is neo-Confucianism, though most of the emperors are also Buddhist adherents. While czarist Russia encroaches on Chinese territory in the north, European merchants begin to arrive by sea along the south coast and establish trade links.



Magnificence of the Manchu

Kangxi (above) was the second Manchu emperor. During his reign (1661–1722), he opened China up to foreign trade and encouraged Western ideas. He added parts of Russia and Tibet to the empire.

1736 Emperor Qianlong comes to power, a patron of Buddhism under whose reign huge amounts of resources are spent on imperial leisure.

1839–60 Opium Wars with Britain and France. Alarmed at the rise in opium use, the Chinese government attempts to limit its import. China is defeated by the British in 1842, and forced to open ports to foreigners. The Manchu are also forced to hand over Hong Kong to the British. China is again defeated in 1860, this time by a combined Anglo-French force. With restrictions lifted, the opium trade thrives and the number of users grows rapidly.

1850–64 Hung Hsiu-chuan proclaims a new dynasty in the Taiping uprising, seizing control of the city of Nanjing and establishing a Christian regime. He declares himself to be the younger brother of Jesus Christ. With the help of UK and US forces, Nanjing is recaptured by the Manchu government in 1864 after a conflict that leaves about 20 million dead. Although victorious, the Manchus' authority is undermined in many parts of China.

1883–85 In the Tonkin War, the French take over control of northern Vietnam from China.

1895 China is defeated by Japan in a war over control of the Korean peninsula.

1900 The Boxer Rebellion, an attempt to expel all foreigners, is suppressed. Foreign troops are now stationed at every important junction between Beijing and Shanghai as the Manchu government is fatally weakened.

1911 Manchu Empire overthrown by nationalists led by Sun Yat-sen. Republic of China declared.

1912 Sun Yat-sen forms the National People's Party (Kuomintang).

1916 Nationalists factionalize. Sun Yat-sen sets up government in Guangdong. Rest of China under control of rival warlords.

1921 The Chinese Communist Party (CCP) is founded in Shanghai at its first national congress, held in a small house and attended by 13 people.

1922 Under pressure from the CCP to formalize his movement's political doctrine, Sun Yat-sen begins a series of lectures outlining his Three Great Principles, which champion nationalism, democracy, and socialism.

1923 The CCP joins Soviet-backed Guomindang to fight the warlords.

1925 Chiang Kai-shek becomes Kuomintang leader on death of Sun Yat-sen.

1927 Chiang turns on the CCP. The CCP leaders escape to rural south.